

WEST

EDITION 2026–27

INFO BOOKLET

For *Parents*

What your son or daughter would do, who they would work with, what it costs and how they are supervised.

WEST VENTURES · AFFILIATED WITH AUSTIN CHRISTIAN UNIVERSITY

GOWEST.VENTURES

Cover: Emanuel Leutze, Westward the Course of Empire Takes Its Way, 1861 (study).

A LETTER

From the managing partners

Thank you for asking about West Ventures. This booklet is written for parents. It explains what a student does here, who they work with, how much time it takes, what it costs, how credit is awarded and how younger students are supervised.

The short version: your son or daughter would join a small team doing real work for an experienced founder or operator, for one term at a time, and earn academic credit for it. The studio's job is to make sure the work is real, the people are worth learning from, and the student is held to a high standard.

Everything in these pages is how the studio operates today. Where a detail is still being set, it says so. If something here does not answer your question, reply to the email this booklet came in and one of us will answer it.

Jake Oswald

MANAGING PARTNER

Lars Ostervold

MANAGING PARTNER

FOR PARENTS

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This booklet is written for parents. Four companion booklets cover the program for students, founders and executives, high schools and universities.

01 · THE STUDIO

What West Ventures is

A venture studio affiliated with Austin Christian University.

West Ventures finds young people with exceptional ability, puts them to work for proven founders and operators, and builds companies with them. It does three things, and each one feeds the others.

I

Teams

Small teams of high school and college students work on real problems for founders and operators, for academic credit. Companies pay nothing.

II

Companies

When a project turns up an opportunity worth building, the studio builds it with the operator who found it, as a joint venture.

III

Network

Partner high schools and universities send their best students. Founders, operators and investors bring the work.

23

Companies served by student teams so far

78

Students who have worked on a team

500

Partner schools planned by 2030

02 · THE MODEL

Kings and *cupbearers*



GUSTAVE DORÉ, NEHEMIAH VIEWS THE RUINS OF JERUSALEM'S WALLS, 1866. NEHEMIAH WAS CUPBEARER TO THE KING.

The thesis is not tied to an industry. The studio's advantage is its model: free work, done by a large group of the country's most capable young people, for the most experienced founders and operators.

The old words for the arrangement are kings and cupbearers. Kings are proven owners and operators with more opportunities than time. Cupbearers are capable young people who need real work and someone to learn from. The studio's job is to match them, at scale.

The arrangement works because each side gets what it lacks. Founders get capable help, at no cost, on work they have no time for. Students get real work, someone to learn from and academic credit. And when a project turns up an opportunity worth building, the studio builds it with the operator who found it, as a joint venture. It expects to start about six companies a year this way.

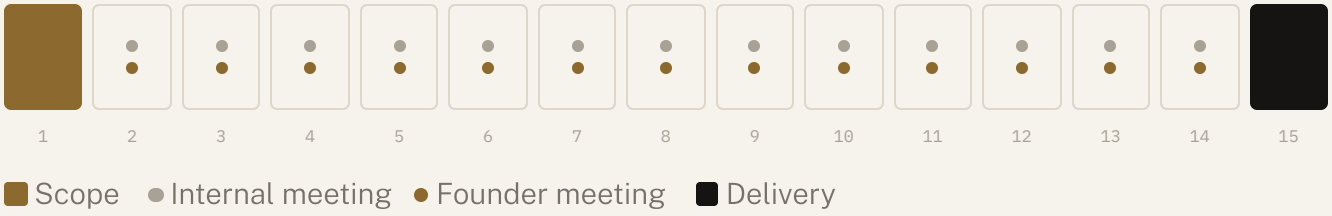
03 · HOW A PROJECT WORKS

How a project works

One team, one founder, one term, one written scope.

A project is one term of work by one team, for one founder or executive. Terms run in fall, spring and summer. The founder brings a real problem and about an hour a week. The company pays nothing and keeps all equity and intellectual property. Students earn academic credit.

A FALL OR SPRING TERM



Before	The studio matches the project with a team and a project lead, and introduces them to the founder.
Week one	The founder and the project lead write the scope: a week-by-week plan of what the team will deliver.
Every week	Two meetings. One internal, with the project lead, on tasks and blockers. One with the founder, to review the work and adjust the scope.
End of term	The team delivers and hands over. The project lead evaluates each student; the founder evaluates the project.
After	Students who delivered are invited back with more responsibility. An opportunity worth building may become a joint venture.

04 · THE TEAM

The team

About five students, an experienced project lead and the founder.



Two college students, one of whom leads the team.

Three high school Builder Scholars, nominated by their schools.

Teams mix students from different schools on purpose. Each team is coached by a volunteer project lead: an experienced professional who runs the internal meeting, keeps the scope honest and evaluates the work. Studio staff oversee every team.

TIME EACH WEEK

Team leader	College student	5 to 10 hours
Contributor	College student	4 to 8 hours
Builder Scholar	High school student	About 3 hours
Project lead	Volunteer professional	Two meetings, plus review
Founder	The company	About 1 hour

05 · EXPECTATIONS

What each party commits to

The arrangement works when everyone does their part. This is what each is asked to do.

Students

- Give the hours the role requires, every week.
- Attend both weekly meetings, prepared.
- Deliver what the scope says, when it says.
- Keep the company's information confidential.
- Represent the company and the studio well.

The project lead

- Run the weekly internal meeting and coach the team.
- Keep the scope current and the founder informed.
- Hold students to the standard the founder expects.
- Evaluate each student's work at the end of the term.

The studio

- Recruit and screen students and project leads.
- Match each project with a team that can deliver it.
- Handle all academic paperwork and credit.
- Oversee every team and step in when a project is off track.

Parents

- Know the weekly time commitment and meeting times.
- Encourage your student to keep commitments to the team.
- Raise any concern with the studio directly.

The founder

- Bring a real problem or opportunity that matters to the business.
- Write the scope with the project lead in week one.
- Meet the team once a week and answer questions in between.
- Give honest feedback, including when the work falls short.
- Evaluate the project at the end of the term.

06 · OUTCOMES FOR STUDENTS

Outcomes for students

Responsibility is earned one term at a time.

01	**Builder Scholar.** A high school student on a team, nominated by their school. Earns college credit.
02	**Contributor.** A college student on a team, doing a defined part of the scope.
03	**Team leader.** Invited after a strong term. Leads the team day to day and answers to the founder.
04	**Fellow.** The studio's most trusted students. Fellows work directly with proven operators on the studio's own companies, two or three at a time.

78

Students who have worked on a team

21

Student Fellows named

2×

Gloo AI Hackathon won by ACU student teams, 2025 and 2026

Every student keeps a record of the work: a public profile listing each company they worked for, their role and what the team delivered, alongside academic credit on a transcript and a reference from a project lead who saw the work.

07 · FROM FAMILIES AND TEACHERS

From families and teachers

PARENT TO BE COLLECTED

"A line from the parent of a Builder Scholar: what changed in their son or daughter over a term."

Name
Parent of a Fall 2026 Builder Scholar

TEACHER TO BE COLLECTED

"A line from a teacher or counselor who nominated students: why they nominated them and what came back."

Name
Teacher, partner high school

STUDENT TO BE COLLECTED

"A line from a Builder Scholar about the work they did and who they did it for."

Name
Builder Scholar, Fall 2026

STUDENT TO BE COLLECTED

"A line from a college team leader about leading a team for a founder."

Name
Team leader, Fall 2026

Families and teachers who would speak with a prospective family directly can be introduced on request.

08 · FROM FOUNDERS

From founders

"Cole has been outstanding on our startup — smart, technically capable, coachable, hardworking, and a true team player. His contribution reflects not only strong technical skill, but the character, humility, and mission-minded leadership ACU is developing in its students."

Paul Kent Graeve
Founder & CEO, Today Matters

"I've spent years working in Big Tech in Silicon Valley with the world's most premiere talent. The profile of the ACU student is unique. The world has a lot of knowledge, but it needs more wisdom. ACU students are showcasing a rigorously intellectual foundation coupled with a moral, Christian fabric — a combo the world desperately needs more of. I wouldn't hesitate to bring an ACU student on."

John Kronlokken
Founder & CEO, Evergreen / Ex-Corporate Strategy, Google

"As an entrepreneur, I wish I had the college experience that ACU is creating. ACU provides students the opportunities they need to become excellent, and the students are delivering on that opportunity. Coming into the engagement, I thought it would be predominantly mentorship. I was wrong. The students delivered tangible value to our organization the whole way through. Movements like this will inspire the next generation of leaders to believe God is in all things, including our work."

Anthony Ruffner
Founder & CEO, Turn

09 · PRICING

Pricing

$5,000

per student, per term.

The same price for high school and college students, who work on the same teams. Companies, partner schools and universities pay nothing.

Terms	Fall, spring and summer. Each is priced and enrolled separately.
A full year	$15,000 for all three terms.
Credit	3 to 6 credit hours a term, awarded through Austin Christian University.
Included	Team placement, a project lead, and academic credit and its paperwork.
Scholarships	Need-based scholarships are available. Price should not keep a capable student out.
Effective	Summer 2027 and later. Earlier terms are priced under the current program.

ONE TERM

$5,000

3 to 6 credit hours

FALL AND SPRING

$10,000

6 to 12 credit hours

FULL YEAR

$15,000

9 to 18 credit hours

10 · STUDY ABROAD

A term *abroad*

Through Living and Learning International, students can live overseas for a term and stay on a team.

Living and Learning International is a faith-based study abroad provider that works with more than forty Christian colleges and universities. Students live in residential communities with resident staff, take courses whose credit transfers home, and live in the culture. West Ventures students can spend a term in one of its locations and keep working with their team remotely, building companies from wherever they are.

Quito *Ecuador*	0.18° S · 78.47° W
Rome *Italy*	41.90° N · 12.50° E
London *England*	51.51° N · 0.13° W

TO CONFIRM Locations, dates and costs are set by Living and Learning and confirmed with each student before a term abroad. Living and Learning's program fees are separate from West Ventures tuition.

11 · SUPERVISION

Supervision

Many Builder Scholars are under 18. This is how the studio works with them.

DRAFT POLICY · TO CONFIRM

ADULTS	Every team has an adult project lead, screened by the studio, and is overseen by studio staff.
MEETINGS	Team meetings are scheduled in advance and held online. Parents may ask for the schedule at any time.
MESSAGES	Team communication happens in studio-managed team channels that staff can see, not in private messages between adults and minors.
TRAVEL	No travel is required. Optional in-person events for students under 18 require a parent's written consent and are chaperoned.
CONCERNS	Parents and students can reach the studio directly about anything, at any time, and will get an answer from staff.

The full conduct and safeguarding policy is available to any parent on request.

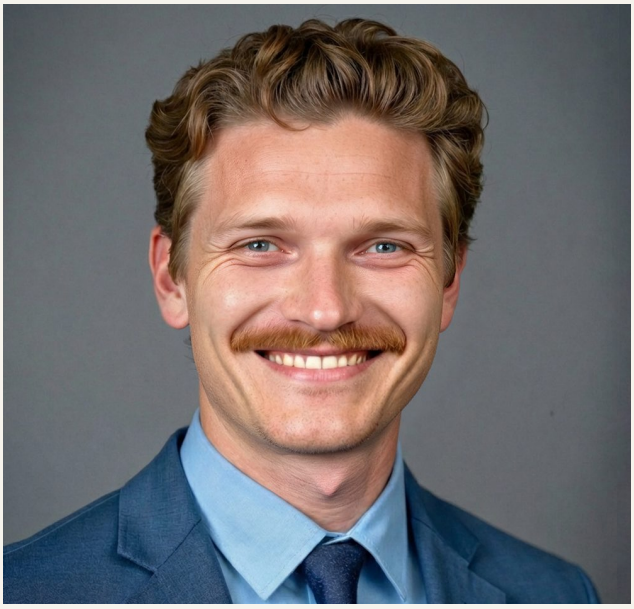
12 · LEADERSHIP

Leadership



Lars Ostervold

MANAGING PARTNER



Jake Oswald

MANAGING PARTNER

LEADERSHIP TEAM

Marshall Cunningham · Head of Operations

Tanner Dobbs · Head of Growth

Nate Steele · Head of Design

Taylore Hopkins · Head of Partnerships

Landen Enns · Head of Investor Relations

BOARD

Ben Peays · Board Chair

Connor Champion · Board Member

John Manning · Board Member

Ryan Wuerch · Board Member

Justin Forman · Board Member

Mark McClain · Board Member

Jake Thomsen · Board Member

13 · QUESTIONS

Questions

Is this a job or a class?

It is a course. Students earn academic credit through Austin Christian University for the work they do on their team. They are not employees of the company they work for, and they are not paid.

How much time does it take?

About 3 hours a week for a high school Builder Scholar, 4 to 8 for a college contributor and 5 to 10 for a team leader. There is no homework and there are no tests beyond the work itself.

Does my student have to live in Austin?

No. Teams work remotely and meet online. Students from partner schools across the country work on the same teams.

Who is my student working with?

A team of about five students, an experienced volunteer project lead, and the founder or executive who brought the project. Studio staff oversee every team.

What if the work is too much alongside school?

Tell the project lead early. Scope is set in the first week and can be adjusted. A student who cannot continue can withdraw under the university's course policies.

Is financial aid available?

Yes. The studio offers need-based scholarships. Price should not keep a capable student out. Ask about scholarships when you apply.

14 · NEXT STEPS

Next steps

1

Ask your questions

Reply to the email this booklet came in. A member of the studio will answer.

2

Apply or be nominated

High school students are nominated by their school or apply directly. College students apply directly. Applications are reviewed each term.

3

Meet the studio

Families can schedule a call with the studio before a student commits to a term.

CONTACT

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WEST

VENTURES

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